

Metaphor Changes Policy Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	metaphor-changes-policy

Big idea: Metaphors guide reasoning.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Crime described as a beast, virus, puzzle, business, or symptom. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Policy options that feel natural under each metaphor. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Metaphor Changes Policy Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A discussion on how metaphors smuggle in causes and solutions. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Metaphors guide reasoning.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Do metaphors reveal truth or create interpretations?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Crime described as a beast, virus, puzzle, business, or symptom.
- Policy options that feel natural under each metaphor.
- A discussion on how metaphors smuggle in causes and solutions.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Activity Steps

1. Give half the class Version A and half Version B.
2. Groups propose three policies.
3. Compare whether solutions are more preventive, diagnostic, punitive or forceful.
4. Reveal that only the metaphor changed.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Do metaphors reveal truth or create interpretations?
- Are some metaphors more ethical than others?
- How do metaphors shape public policy and science communication?

Knowledge Questions

- Do metaphors reveal truth or create interpretations?
- Are some metaphors more ethical than others?
- How do metaphors shape public policy and science communication?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with crime described as a beast, virus, puzzle, business, or symptom. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...